BATTLES FOR THE MEDITERRANEAN



The sack of Constantinople
Venice contracted with the organizers of the Forth Crusade to ship their army to Egypt. When the crusaders were unable to pay the full sum, the fleet was diverted to the Byzantine capital, Constantinople, where, in 1204 the Venetians and crusaders ended up capturing and sacking the city.

DURING THE THOUSAND YEARS between 500 and 1500 CE maritime powers rose and fell in the Mediterranean. The initial dominance of the Byzantine Empire, the successor state to Rome, was first challenged by the Muslim Arabs, then supplanted by the Italian maritime republics, Venice, Genoa, and Pisa, and by the Catalan galleys of the kingdom of Aragon. With no single state capable of achieving command of the sea, outbreaks of naval warfare were inevitable. Innovative weaponry, from Greek fire to the crossbow, produced important changes in combat at sea, as did variation in ship design and rowing systems. But galleys still predominated and boarding the enemy remained the essential goal in battle, as it had been in Roman times.

TACTICS AND TECHNOLOGY

The dominant warship of the period of Byzantine-Arab wars was the dromon. This was a formidable platform for marines, catapults, and flamethrowers, heading into battle propelled not only by up to 100 oarsmen but also by sails—a radical departure from the practice of the ancient world. The raised beak at the prow of the dromon would smash through an opponent's oars and provide a bridge for boarding soldiers to swarm across. Oarsmen were expected to take up arms and join the fighting once the enemy was engaged at close quarters. From the 12th century the crossbow was introduced as an important element in Mediterranean sea battles. The Genoese and the Aragonese were especially famed for their use of this weapon. It added a deadly new element to the array of missiles hurled against an enemy as galleys closed for combat—which included incendiary grenades, darts, containers filled with soap thrown onto the opponent's deck to make it slippery under foot, and lime dust intended to blind the enemies' eyes. Galleys entered battle in line abreast, each ship protecting its neighbor's vulnerable flank. Maintaining formation was considered of far greater importance than maneuver—galleys were sometimes loosely linked together with cables, to keep them in line and prevent an enemy from penetrating between them.

WEAPONS AND TECHNOLOGY

GREEK FIRE

The inflammable liquid known as "Greek fire" was reportedly invented by an engineer called Callanicus in Constantinople around 670 CE. It was used chiefly in incendiary grenades and flamethrowers. A small catapult on deck propelled clay jars containing the substance onto enemy ships; the jar broke apart and the fire ignited. Alternatively, a bronze tube was mounted at the prow of a ship, through which the Greek fire was pumped, projecting a stream of flame. For psychological effect, the tube of the flamethrower often stuck out from the mouth of a carved dragon's or lion's head. It was known as a "siphon." The composition of Greek fire was a carefully guarded secret and can still only be guessed at. It was employed in Byzantine naval warfare for five centuries.



Greek fire in action
The few contemporary illustrations of ships using Greek fire in battle give little clue as to its composition or how it was propelled.

SHIFTING POWER

Similar tactics and technology were used by all sides in medieval Mediterranean naval conflict. For example, the dromon and its style of warfare—including the use of Greek fire—was invented by the Byzantines but was over time adopted by the Arabs as well. Relative success in naval warfare depended upon material resources and seafaring and fighting skills. Once it had resisted the initial Arab onslaught in the 7th and early 8th centuries, which briefly threatened to overrun Constantinople, the Byzantine Empire remained a dominant presence at sea in the eastern Mediterranean because it could afford a large fleet and dockyards.

From the end of the 11th century the balance of naval power shifted as maritime trade brought rising wealth to relatively small states further west. The Italian republics of Venice and Genoa had populations of only a few hundred thousand, but their involvement in the Crusades in the 12th and 13th centuries brought them a dominant position in the trade of the Levant and the Black Sea. This provided them with the